

12-YEAR TOPPERS

ENGINEERING

Years	1st Place	2nd Place	3rd place
2008	IIT Delhi	IIT Kanpur	IIT Mumbai
2007	IIT Kanpur	IIT Delhi	IIT Chennai
2006	IIT Delhi	IIT Kanpur	IIT Mumbai
2005	IIT Delhi	IIT Mumbai	IIT Chennai
2004	IIT Kanpur	IIT Delhi	IIT Mumbai
2003	IIT Kharagpur	IIT Kanpur	IIT Mumbai
2002	IIT Kharagpur	IIT Kanpur	BITS, Pilani
2001	IIT Kharagpur	IIT Kanpur	BITS, Pilani, IIT, Chennai, Delhi, Mumbai
2000	IIT Mumbai	IIT Chennai	IIT Delhi
1999	IIT Kanpur	IIT Mumbai	IIT Delhi
1998	IIT Mumbai	IIT Kanpur	IIT Delhi
1997	IITs were excluded. IISc (Bangalore), Roorklee College of Engineering and REC (Tiruchirappalli) were top 3.		

MEDICINE

Years	1st Place	2nd Place	3rd place
2008	AIIMS, Delhi	CMC, Vellore	AFMC, Pune
2007	AIIMS, Delhi	AFMC, Pune	CMC, Vellore
2006	AIIMS, Delhi	CMC, Vellore	AFMC, Pune
2005	AIIMS, Delhi	AFMC, Pune	SJMC, Bangalore
2004	AIIMS, Delhi	BMC, Bangalore	KMC, Manipal
2003	AIIMS, Delhi	CMC, Vellore	AFMC, Pune
2002	CMC, Vellore	AIIMS, Delhi	JIPMER, Puducherry
2001	AIIMS, Delhi	AFMC, Pune	LWMC, Delhi
2000	AIIMS, Delhi	CMC, Vellore	AFMC, Pune
1999	AIIMS, Delhi	CMC, Vellore	JIPMER, Puducherry
1998	AIIMS, Delhi	CMC, Vellore	JIPMER, Puducherry
1997	AIIMS, Delhi	CMC, Vellore	JIPMER, Puducherry

Academy of Legal Studies and Research (NALSAR), Hyderabad, which pulled off the impossible by toppling National Law School India University (NLSIU), Bangalore, from the number one slot in the law stream. NALSAR is a relative newcomer compared to its venerable Bangalore counterpart. Part of the reason for its triumph this year is its emphasis on providing world class infrastructure facilities that include virtual universal classrooms combined with outstanding faculty and consistency in training. Perceptually, NLSIU may have scored top marks but it compares poorly with NALSAR in its factual ratings. So after years we have a new winner in the law category.

The big message then of the 2008 survey is that to be in the league of extraordinary colleges, do the ordinary things extraordinarily well. The other is that, like justice, it is not enough for colleges to do it but equally important to be seen to be doing it. Many principals are puzzled that their previous years'

efforts to improve the college facilities have not seen a marked improvement in their rankings in the poll. Unless that effort is publicised or brought to the notice of their peers, the perception of the college will not radically change.

If INDIA TODAY's poll focusses on perception, it's for good reason: its next to impossible to collect authentic factual data on the 18,000-odd colleges in India and then evaluate it according to a set of criteria that requires physical inspection of the premises as well as interviews with its key staff. The University Grants

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Commission set up the National Assessment and Accreditation Council (NAAC) in 1994 to do this. But in 14 years it's been able to cover a little over 3,500 colleges or a fifth of the total number. So perforce any such survey would have to be largely based on perception with some weightage to factual scores.

For precisely this reason the INDIA TODAY-AC Nielsen-ORG-MARG annual survey of academic excellence is modelled the way it is: the final ranking is determined with a 70:30 per cent weightage given to perceptual and factual scores, respectively.

The process of the survey starts in January, with the agency preparing a list of 1,400 colleges in the six streams of arts, science, commerce, medicine, engineering and law across 12 major Indian cities: Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai, Bangalore, Kolkata, Hyderabad, Lucknow, Ahmedabad, Chandigarh, Pune, Kochi and Jaipur. Then in a two-stage process (see *methodology*) these colleges are ranked by 400 experts to narrow the list down to around 460 colleges. After which another set of 400 experts select 225 colleges for the national ranking process.

The result was a more robust polling technique both at the national and the city level. This year, as in the last, the survey gives top 50 national rankings for arts, science and commerce and top 25 for engineering, medicine and law. As an added bonus, instead of the usual first five rankings for city colleges in arts, science and commerce, there are top 10 ranks in the major metros. This widens the choice for students in these cities aspiring to join these colleges.

There would be the usual heartburn and grumbling by colleges dissatisfied by their individual rankings. But colleges like NALSAR and IIT Delhi have shown that by focussing on constant improvement through innovation, their ranks could improve dramatically. The sign on the door of opportunity says PUSH. So for those colleges that didn't make it or were disappointed by their rankings, the door to excellence is always open. All they have to do is enter. ■